

Smoked Gouda Mac and Cheese

A Southern comfort staple taught at Jake's Table and one of the ongoing recipe blog drafts. This is the anchor recipe of the Southern Comfort Foundations track - the dish that teaches students how to build a proper béchamel, how to melt cheese without breaking a sauce, and how to season a creamy dish in layers. It is also the most consistently requested recipe at the end of every class.

Ingredients (serves 8 as a class, 6 as a main)

Pasta

- 1 lb elbow macaroni or cavatappi
- Salted water for boiling

Cheese Sauce

- 3 tbsp unsalted butter
- 3 tbsp all-purpose flour
- 3 cups whole milk, warmed
- 1 cup heavy cream
- 3 cups sharp white cheddar, freshly grated (not pre-shredded)
- 1 cup smoked gouda, rind removed and grated
- ½ tsp mustard powder
- ¼ tsp cayenne pepper
- ¼ tsp freshly grated nutmeg
- 1½ tsp kosher salt
- Black pepper to taste

Breadcrumb Topping

- 1 cup panko breadcrumbs
 - 2 tbsp unsalted butter, melted
 - ¼ cup grated parmesan
 - 1 tsp smoked paprika
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Cheese Sauce Method

The sauce is a mornay - a béchamel with cheese. The technique is foundational and transfers directly to gratins, croque monsieur, and soufflés. Getting it right is a matter of respecting the heat.

1. **Make the roux.** Melt butter in a heavy-bottomed saucepan over medium heat. Add flour all at once. Stir constantly with a wooden spoon or silicone spatula for 2-3 minutes. The roux should bubble gently and smell slightly nutty - not raw or burnt. This is a blond roux.

2. **Add the warm milk.** Remove the pan from heat briefly and add about one-third of the warm milk, whisking vigorously to prevent lumps. Return to medium heat and add the remaining milk in two

additions, whisking continuously between each. Add the heavy cream.

3. **Cook the béchamel.** Stir constantly over medium heat until the sauce thickens and coats the back of a spoon - about 5-7 minutes. Reduce heat to low.

4. **Add the cheese.** Remove from heat completely. Add the grated cheddar and gouda in three additions, stirring between each until smooth. Adding cheese off heat prevents the proteins from seizing and breaking the emulsion. If the sauce is still on the burner when the cheese goes in, you will get a grainy, greasy result.

5. **Season.** Add mustard powder, cayenne, nutmeg, salt, and black pepper. Taste. The sauce should be bold - it will mellow when baked with pasta and topping.

Assembly and Bake

1. Cook pasta 2 minutes less than the package al dente time - it will finish in the oven. Drain but do not rinse (surface starch helps the sauce cling).

2. Combine hot pasta with the cheese sauce in the saucepan or a large bowl. Stir until fully coated. Transfer to a buttered 9x13-inch baking dish.

3. Combine panko, melted butter, parmesan, and smoked paprika. Sprinkle evenly over the top.

4. Bake at 375°F (190°C) for 25-30 minutes until the topping is deeply golden and the edges are bubbling.

5. Rest 5 minutes before serving. The sauce will tighten slightly as it cools to a creamy, spoonable consistency.

Technique Notes

Grate your own cheese. Pre-shredded cheese is coated in cellulose or potato starch to prevent clumping in the bag. This coating inhibits melting and produces a grainy sauce. Grating fresh from the block takes an extra five minutes and makes a substantial difference.

Warm the milk. Cold milk added to a hot roux creates lumps and forces the cook to whisk aggressively while the sauce scalds. Warming milk in a separate saucepan or the microwave takes 90 seconds and eliminates this problem.

Adjust consistency before baking. If the sauce seems very thick, add up to ½ cup additional warm milk before transferring to the baking dish. The pasta will absorb liquid during the bake, and a slightly looser sauce going in means a perfectly creamy result coming out.

Variations

Lobster mac: Fold 1 lb poached and chopped lobster meat into the pasta-sauce mixture before baking. Omit cayenne; add a pinch of white pepper and tarragon.

Jalapeño mac: Add 2 seeded and minced jalapeños sautéed in butter to the sauce. Substitute pepper jack for half the cheddar. Top with crushed tortilla chips instead of panko.

Vegan adaptation: Use 4 tbsp vegan butter, oat milk instead of whole milk, 1 cup raw cashews soaked and blended with nutritional yeast and lemon juice as the cheese base. Texture will differ but the sauce

building technique is identical.

Teaching Notes

Schedule this class for the first session of the Southern Comfort track. The béchamel technique is the most transferable skill in the curriculum - students who can make a proper béchamel can make a dozen other dishes. The bake time (25 minutes) gives 20-25 minutes for cleanup, plating discussion, and question-and-answer before the shared meal.

- Demo the roux first, explaining the butter-to-flour ratio and color stages
- Have students take turns whisking at the stove during the milk addition stage
- Do a blind taste of pre-shredded vs. fresh-grated cheese melted in warm milk - the difference is immediately obvious
- Let the baking dish rest the full 5 minutes before serving - students learn patience by observing it thicken